

changed, and experiments to run, and technology to improve, all fueled by a user base willing to spend more and more money on the devices in order to have an even better experience.

Vast

Look at the internet. Is there anyone of us who can say we are done with it? Can any one of us say we have seen all we needed to see on the internet and there is nothing more that interests us anymore? A metaverse needs to be vast, so vast in fact, that it always holds the promise of delivering a new and improved experience, and a feeling of excitement when coming back to it. YouTube is the same. You open up the app, it shows you a bunch of videos you haven't seen before and you scroll through them choosing one you have never seen before, and then watch it. Then you watch another suggested video, and another, and pretty soon you end up watching a one hour video some guy restoring an ancient coal iron used to iron clothes in the 17th century. Or you watch a guy in Malaysia or some place use only his hands and rudimentary tools to dig out a huge hole in the ground, and then make a mud palace in the middle of nowhere! Why do we do this? Who knows. Yet it feels so satisfying to end up at some random video of someone doing something you'd never even thought about before.

Monetary gain

There has to be something in it for the people who support the metaverse. The creators and the developers need to make money, or else there is only so much free time someone is willing to put into a task without reward. Even if you love your job, would you do it for free? And even if you say yes you would, would you do it 8 hours a day? No, because you'd starve and have no place to stay. The world runs off a simple principle of bartering services for reward. On the internet currently it's advertising that is the economic system. People prefer not to pay for services, instead subjecting themselves to less than ideal user experiences in order to get free content. This is usually in the form of ads

or paid promotions, or sometimes, with sneaky publishers and individuals, paid promotions are masked as actual content. On YouTube there are 30 million people who pay for their Premium service and are not therefore subjected to advertising, the rest watch ads on videos (or rather ignore ads on videos), and get the same content for free. Any new metaverse will also run on a very similar system.

Laws or rules

There have to be laws and rules, because places that don't have these soon become cesspools that no one wants to use. This is why you can get banned off social media if you repeat-



Source: Unit 2 Games Ltd.

Are we already there?

edly abuse or harass people. You also get banned from pretty much any internet service for breaking rules, such as violating copyright on YouTube repeatedly, or cheating in online games. In very extreme circumstances, real world laws are used to punish some people who break the laws of a country they reside in. There is a global push led by law enforcement of all countries to clamp down on child exploitation, for example. Then again, in some countries you can be arrested for blasphemy, or hurting someone's religious sentiments, or for making threats of harm against people. Either way, a metaverse has to have rules and laws that people have to follow, and then have consequences if those laws are broken. All internet services already have this.

Immersion

This is the real metaverse experi-

ence. It has got to feel real. And no, that doesn't mean that VR is the only way to go. Think about it, you watch a movie in a theatre, and there are scary scenes that actually cause your heart to race. There are emotional scenes that cause you to shed a tear or even cry your eyes out! All of these are examples of content and experiences being emotional. There are YouTube channels dedicated to doing good deeds for people, and helping people out.

So many of us have had to live life on video chat, because we have been separated from family or loved ones who are far away from us, in different cities, or even different countries.

Many people have had to attend events virtually, and these have been everything from births, marriages to even funerals, and the emotions we have felt while witnessing those events are as real as ever.

So is there anything the metaverse will bring us that we don't already have? Sure it will do it slightly differently and we will hear of new company names and platforms, and need new hardware to access that. However, if being human, and curious, and wanting to connect with people from across the globe, work and have fun and entertain ourselves is what the metaverse is about, then aren't we already in one? Is it just the graphics that will improve?

As always, write in and let us know your expectations from the metaverse, and what you thought about our cover story on the topic. And watch this space for more on the metaverse as it happens. **d**